



Celebratory finish: Delhi LG Vinai Kumar Saxena and event ambassador Carl Lewis with elite men's podium finishers Alex Matata (gold), Boyelign Teshager (silver), and James Kipkogei (bronze) at the 20th Vedanta Delhi Half Marathon. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

understand him. I understand that he's trying to market and brand himself. Of all the athletes in the world today, I probably see the most of myself in him.

If you could go back in time and meet the 17-year-old Carl Lewis, what would you tell him?

I'd tell him the same thing I tell all the young athletes I coach: Listen.

You have two ears and one mouth — listen more. Your elders know a lot more than you think they do.

The Olympics are coming back to Los Angeles. What's that going to be like?

I think the Games are going to be fabulous. The Olympics bring people together. Paris was incredible, and L.A. will be the same. I'm really looking forward to taking some of our young athletes there. I don't know what it will feel like walking into the Coliseum with one of them, watching them run their rounds. My role has changed — it's like being a parent. One day, you realise you've become the adult guiding someone else. It will be very emotional.

The last time the Olympics were in L.A., there was the Soviet boycott. Now there's political division at home — Trump, the culture wars. Do you see parallels?

Honestly, I don't think America is any more divided than it's always been. The difference is that this administration allowed people to say things openly. People feel free to be evil, racist, and ignorant. But this country has always been divided — by race and by gender.

The racism and misogyny were always there. What's changed is that now, under Trump, people feel permitted to say these things publicly.

But you know what? I'm a Black man — this is the life I've always lived. So now people around the world say, "This is terrible!" Well, this has always been our reality.

In a strange way, maybe it's not entirely bad that people say these things out loud now. Because once you're out, you can't go back in.

L.A. will probably be important for track and field, too. Back when you were at your peak, the sport was everywhere. Now it doesn't have the same cultural dominance. How do you fix that?

Unfortunately, I don't think we can. In the 1980s and '90s, we fought hard to make the sport professional. Then, in the 2000s, people thought the job was done — and they took their foot off the gas. Other sports



Born to fly

- * Undefeated in the long jump for 65 consecutive competitions (1981–1991) — one of the longest winning streaks in athletics history
- * His 1984 Olympic quadruple gold replicated Jesse Owens's 1936 feat
- * Won a total of nine Olympic gold medals and one silver, along with eight gold, one silver, and one bronze at the World Championships
- * Inducted into the USA Track & Field Hall of Fame (2001) and IAAF Hall of Fame (2012)
- * His mother, Evelyn Lawler, was also a sprinter who competed for the U.S. national team
- * Served as a UN Goodwill Ambassador and has engaged in various humanitarian causes

have passed us by. I don't think we're going back to those glory days. In many ways, we've regressed. Athletes make less money now than we did in the 1990s. They have less power and less control. It's almost like the old amateur era again.

To recover, athletes would have to do a lot of work. Some are starting to realise the sport's in trouble — but what are they going to do about it? I don't think enough people have the stomach for that fight.

The best thing we can do now is hold on to what we have.